



**Acceptance speech for 1st
Breaking Borders Award in Technology**
Archbishop John Baptist Odama, Gulu

Brothers and Sisters in God and Humanity,



On behalf of the people of Northern Uganda I am pleased to accept this Breaking Borders Award for BOSCO. As perhaps you know, Northern Uganda is recovering from 22 years of war and relentless cultural scouring. Children have grown up almost without hope, seemingly without a future, confronted with the threat of conscription into child soldiery or sexual slavery, and with the certainty of growing up without the minimal conditions necessary for inheriting the richness of their culture and promise of their land.

In the midst of this affliction our people have been plagued by a further suffering, a deep isolation from the rest of humanity, a situation captured by Jan Eglund when he described it as “the world’s worst forgotten humanitarian crisis.” And yet even as our circumstances have become better known to the world, the danger remains that we may take our place on the conveyor belt of sad international news items, an endless litany of need eliciting expressions of concern lasting as long as the day’s headlines.

Children need more than passing expressions of concern. Northern Uganda prior to the present fragile peace has been called the worst place in the world to be a child. No one would tolerate such an upbringing for their own children. Indeed, I know as chair of the Acholi Religious Leaders’ Peace Initiative that the people of Northern Uganda have not tolerated these circumstances but have acted to establish peace, reaching out in dialogue and forgiveness to our oppressors. Still, the scars of war remain, and outstrip the means of the people to restore critical elements of a dignified way of life. But much of the world isn’t richly aware, doesn’t really believe, that the children of Northern Uganda, as all children, are indeed their own children. In this lack of awareness lies a second great poverty, less pressing but more insidious than the very real poverty of being denied the basic means of physical and cultural subsistence.

Against both these forms of poverty the true significance of Information and Communications Technologies is revealed. More than an infrastructure to promote economic development, ICT can amplify the voices of the oppressed and magnify the efforts of others who would stand together with them against dehumanizing forces. Emerging ICT technologies are vascularizing new and richer forms of human community. These communities are characterized by greater levels of freedom for every individual, where each member is empowered to bring wisdom, love and initiative to bear on their circumstances, working together with like-minded collaborators from anywhere on the globe.

War and isolation put Northern Uganda more than two decades behind the rest of the world in the use of modern communications technologies. But for the past three years, BOSCO-- Battery Operated Systems for Community Outreach--is quickly catching up. BOSCO deploys information, communications and collaboration technologies to strengthen communities in rural schools, community centers, health clinics, human rights organizations, and even local government offices. In today's world, modern communications technology should be enjoyed and used by all. No longer should we have to rely on Western media outlets to report our stories, our successes and our challenges. BOSCO is increasingly empowering us to participate in this global conversation.

To highlight one success story: BOSCO has amplified the voice of a local catechist and school teacher, Jokondino Okema, who has posted regularly to Wikispaces about what it was like to teach children in a war zone within a camp for Internally Displaced Persons during the slow transition to peace. His students are currently mapping water quality data in science classes in collaboration with a classroom of students in the US whose teacher found Jokondino's posts on the internet and raised funds to support this classroom-to-classroom project. We were unable to secure a passport in time for Jokondino to travel here for this Global Voices Summit, but you can find him online.

BOSCO in Northern Uganda is building a collaboration pipeline designed to enable civility, decency, and solidarity to flow in both directions for the healing of oppressed, oppressor and bystander, all alike. Together with our collaborators and supporters--The Zuehlke Family Foundation, Inveneo, Wikispaces, the University of Notre Dame and BOSCO Incorporated from the United States, Horizont3000 from Austria, War Child Holland, Human Rights Focus from Gulu, and UNICEF-Uganda--BOSCO Uganda is working toward a future where the children of the oppressed work toward peace hand in hand with the children of the oppressors. We are honored by the solidarity shown to us by Global Voices and the supporters of this Breaking Borders Award. We commit ourselves to using the resources and exposure that come with this award to further expand opportunities for our people to lift their voices in opposition to isolation and to collaborate with others from around the globe to build a lasting peace.

Santiago de Chile, 6th of May 2010